Cross-Cultural Validation and Ideological Fairness of a Historical Perspective Taking Instrument: Evidence from Czech Secondary Students

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Abstract

This study reports ~~the first~~ a Czech adaptation of the Hartmann and Hasselhorn Historical Perspective Taking (HPT) instrument and examines whether its politically charged scenario introduces construct-irrelevant variance (CIV) related to students' ideological attitudes. Among 293 Czech secondary students, confirmatory factor analysis ~~(CFA)~~ ~~confirmed the~~ showed good fit for a correlated three-factor ~~structure. Item Response Theory (IRT)-based differential item functioning (DIF)~~ model. An item-level bias analysis detected no ~~biased items~~ differential item functioning across ideology groups with this sample and procedure. Multi-group ~~CFA demonstrated full scalar measurement invariance~~factor analysis produced fit-index changes compatible with scalar invariance,

but small extreme groups and unmodeled clustering limit the strength of that evidence. Historical knowledge ~~predicted HPT scores; ideology was unrelated~~ correlated with the six-item HPT composite (r = .34, 95% CI [.23, .43]); right-authoritarian attitudes were unrelated (r = −.05, 95% CI [−.16, .07]). These findings support a ~~transferable~~ possible protocol for evaluating measurement fairness when assessment content carries attitudinal valence, subject to the limits of this single scenario, item format, and ideologically restricted sample.

Keywords: historical perspective taking, cross-cultural validation, measurement invariance, differential item functioning, construct-irrelevant variance, test fairness

1. Introduction

Cross-cultural adaptation of educational and psychological instruments requires more than linguistic translation: it demands evidence that the adapted version measures the same construct, with equivalent psychometric properties, in the target population (Hambleton et al., 2005; International Test Commission, 2017). When assessment content carries attitudinal valence—when scenarios, stimuli, or items touch on beliefs that respondents may hold—an additional fairness question arises: does the content introduce construct-irrelevant variance (CIV) by functioning differently for subgroups whose attitudes align with that content (Messick, 1995)? This question is especially pressing for scenario-based instruments in the social sciences, where rich contextual material is needed to elicit complex reasoning but may simultaneously activate respondents' pre-existing attitudes. Historical perspective taking (HPT)—the capacity to reconstruct the beliefs, values, and cir-

cumstances that made past actors' decisions intelligible in their own time (Hartmann & Hasselhorn, 2008; Lee & Ashby, 2001)—provides a particularly informative case. HPT instruments routinely use politically and morally charged historical scenarios as the stimulus for disciplinary reasoning (reasoning according to the methodological norms of the historical discipline, such as source criticism and ~~contextualisation~~contextualization; van Drie & van Boxtel, 2008; Seixas & Morton, 2013; Wineburg, 2001).

The instrument ~~developed by~~ is among the most extensively validated standardized ~~HPTmeasures in European research. Originally~~ reported by Hartmann and Hasselhorn (2008) provides a scenario-based measure of HPT. It was validated with German ~~secondary students , it has been adapted for use in the Netherlands and employed in comparative studies of historical reasoning~~Grade 10 students (Hartmann & Hasselhorn, 2008) and subsequently translated and studied with Dutch students aged 10–17 (Huijgen et al., 2014, 2017). This evidence base is promising but remains concentrated in two language contexts and a small number of studies. The instrument operationalizes HPT through a scenario-based approach in which students read about a historically situated dilemma and ~~respond to nine Likert-scaled items capturing three developmental levels: presentism/othering of people~~ rate how well nine explanations fit the situation on a four-point response scale in three interpretive response categories: present-oriented perspective (POP), ~~recognition of the agent's social role and situational context~~ role of the historical agent (ROA), and historical contextualization (CONT). ~~This structure reflects a theoretical progression from naive~~ POP and CONT represent the clearest contrast between present-centered judgment ~~toward increasingly sophisticated historical~~

~~reasoning~~and contextual reasoning; ROA's position as an intermediate level remains theoretically less certain (Hartmann & Hasselhorn, 2008; Lee & Ashby, 2001).

The present study reports ~~the first~~ a Czech adaptation and psychometric evaluation of the Hartmann and Hasselhorn HPT instrument. Two considerations motivate this work. First, no validated Czech-language HPT instrument ~~currently exists, despite growing interest in historical thinking assessment within Czech education reform . The Czech adaptation addresses this gap and provides the research community with a tool for cross-cultural comparisons of HPT development~~was identified. Czech initiatives have developed digital historical-literacy tasks and measures of epistemic beliefs about history (Činátl et al., 2021; Ripka et al., 2024); the present adaptation provides a candidate instrument for further Czech validation and future cross-national equivalence studies.

Second, the instrument's scenario content raises a specific fairness question. ~~The scenario describes a young man in the Weimar Republic deliberating whether to join an extremist political movement. Items that require students to contextualize this figure's reasoning~~ Hannes discusses Germany's crisis and the 1930 election; students judge how well nine explanations fit his situation, including whether he could vote for an anti-democratic party such as the NSDAP. These judgments could, in principle, function differently for students whose political attitudes align with the scenario's ideological content. Students with right-authoritarian sympathies might find it cognitively easier to endorse contextualizing responses—not because they are reasoning historically, but because the responses resonate with their own attitudes. If present, such a pattern would constitute construct-irrelevant variance (CIV): systematic score variation attributable to a factor

extraneous to the target construct (American Educational Research Association et al., 2014; Messick, 1995).

This concern is not merely theoretical. Research on identity-protective cognition demonstrates that individuals process information through the lens of pre-existing beliefs (Jost et al., 2003; Kahan et al., 2017). Recent work has documented how ideological content can infiltrate competence judgments in history assessment, whether through teacher scoring bias in open-ended narrative assessment (Alvén, 2019) or through construct comparability challenges in cross-cultural settings (Badham et al., 2025). The question central to the present study is whether the HPT instrument's psychometric properties—its factor structure, item parameters, and score interpretations—hold equivalently across students with different political attitudes, or whether politically charged content introduces measurement bias.

The study contributes to the literature in three ways: (a) it ~~demonstrates a transferable~~ applies a possible methodological approach for evaluating whether attitudinally charged assessment content introduces construct-irrelevant variance, (b) it provides DIF and ~~measurement invariance evidence for a fairness-relevant grouping variable—political ideology—that has not previously been examined in HPT measurement~~measurement-invariance evidence across political-ideology groups, and (c) it ~~reports the first published Czech validation of the Hartmann and Hasselhorn HPT instrument, extending the~~ adds Czech evidence to the small cross-cultural evidence base for this measure. To establish this evidence, ~~we~~ I conducted confirmatory factor analysis (CFA), reliability analysis, intraclass correlation estimation, IRT-based differential item functioning (DIF) analysis, and

multi-group CFA for measurement invariance testing.

2. Literature Review

2.1 Historical Perspective Taking and Its Measurement

HPT refers to the ability to understand past actors' decisions by reconstructing the historical context in which they operated (Hartmann & Hasselhorn, 2008; Lee & Ashby, 2001). HPT is a second-order (procedural or disciplinary) concept—as distinct from first-order (substantive) concepts such as "revolution" or "empire," it concerns the meta-level reasoning processes historians use to make sense of the past (Seixas & Peck, 2004). The concept has roots in British traditions that progressively refined the construct from historical empathy (Ashby & Lee, 1987; Shemilt, 1984) toward rational reconstruction (Lee & Ashby, 2001). It has been situated within broader frameworks of historical reasoning that encompass evidence use, argumentation, and substantive concept deployment—the application of domain-specific content knowledge about events, causes, and actors (van Boxtel & van Drie, 2018; van Drie & van Boxtel, 2008; VanSledright, 2013). The literature variously labels this capacity "historical empathy," "perspective taking," or "rational reconstruction." ~~We follow~~ I follow Hartmann and Hasselhorn (2008) in adopting the term "perspective taking" within the rationalist tradition of ~~, which emphasises~~ Lee and Ashby (2001), which emphasizes cognitive reconstruction of context rather than affective identification with past actors (see Barton & Levstik, 2004, for a contrasting view that ~~emphasises~~ emphasizes affective engagement alongside cognitive reconstruction; see also ~~, for a more recent treatment~~ Endacott & Brooks, 2013; Endacott, 2014, for treatments

of the empathy/perspective-taking distinction). The present instrument therefore operationalizes cognitive perspective taking, not the fuller cognitive-affective construct of historical empathy. Across these frameworks, HPT is understood as a cognitively demanding, knowledge-dependent competence—not a disposition but a disciplinary achievement requiring both domain-specific knowledge and the capacity to deploy that knowledge in reconstructing past perspectives (Chapman, 2021; VanSledright, 2013; Wineburg, 2001). Distinguishing genuine disciplinary reasoning from attitude-driven responding is a measurement challenge that extends beyond HPT to epistemic cognition in history more broadly (Maggioni et al., 2009).

~~operationalised HPT into a developmental model with three levels:~~ Hartmann and Hasselhorn (2008) operationalized HPT using three response categories: ~~*presentism*~~*present-oriented perspective* (POP), where students judge historical actors by contemporary standards; ~~*recognition*~~ *role of the historical agent~~'s role~~* (ROA), where students ~~acknowledge the agent's social position without full contextual reconstruction~~explain action through familiar or stereotyped social roles; and *contextualization* (CONT), where students situate decisions within the specific historical conditions that rendered them intelligible. ~~This developmental progression from present-centred judgment toward contextualisation~~ The POP–CONT continuum from present-centered judgment toward contextualization has empirical parallels in earlier work on students' historical understanding (Lee & Shemilt, 2003). The original published validation study (n = 170 German students, Grade 10~~)~~ ~~recovered three levels through principal component analysis~~ ; Hartmann & Hasselhorn, 2008) placed raw POP and CONT at opposing poles of one principal component and

ROA on a second, less clearly interpreted component (explained variance = 51%)~~, and students classified at the highest level~~ ; a separate latent-class analysis identified three student classes. Students classified in the highest class had significantly better history grades; however, PCA is an exploratory technique, and the present study ~~provides the first confirmatory factor analytic test of the three-level structure. The instrument was extended by and~~ tests a correlated three-factor representation rather than reproducing the original PCA dimensions. Huijgen et al. (2014) replicated the two-dimensional pattern for the Nazi-party scenario with Dutch students, but transfer of the item-rating approach to a slavery scenario produced weaker reliability and validity evidence. Wilschut and Schiphorst (2019) adapted the format to two new scenarios (a nineteenth-century strike and an eleventh-century crusade) with 69 Dutch Grade 10 students; principal components did not recover the three response categories, and total-score reliability was low (α = .22 and .50). Huijgen et al. (2017) ~~, who confirmed the core theoretical structure while highlighting the difficulty of contextualization for most students .~~ subsequently combined the closed item ratings with think-alouds and documented how students interpreted and sometimes misunderstood the response options. Thus, successful reuse of the Nazi scenario does not establish that the format transfers unchanged across topics or elicits the intended process. A recent Turkish qualitative case study of sixth- and eighth-grade students used the Hartmann and Hasselhorn framework and its components to analyze students' understanding of the Turkish Alphabet Reform (Aktın et al., 2026). The full-text report uses those components as deductive analytic categories; it does not establish direct administration or psychometric performance of this nine-item instrument.

The difficulty of measuring HPT stems from its inherently interpretive character. Unlike factual recall, HPT cannot be ~~assessed through simple multiple-choice items with single correct answers~~ adequately inferred from decontextualized factual-recall items alone (Breakstone, 2014; Smith, 2017). Scenario-based instruments address this challenge by presenting contextual information and requiring students to evaluate statements reflecting different levels of historical reasoning (Hartmann & Hasselhorn, 2008; Seixas et al., 2015). However, this approach introduces a measurement tension: the richer the historical context, the more opportunity for construct-irrelevant factors—including attitudes toward that content—to influence responses.

2.2 Cross-Cultural Test Adaptation

The adaptation of educational and psychological instruments across languages and cultures requires systematic procedures to ensure that the adapted version measures the same construct as the original (Hambleton et al., 2005; International Test Commission, 2017). The International Test Commission (ITC) guidelines emphasize that adaptation involves more than translation: it requires attention to construct equivalence, cultural appropriateness, and technical quality of the adapted version (International Test Commission, 2017). For instruments used in history education, cross-cultural adaptation faces the additional challenge that historical content may carry different resonances across national contexts. A scenario about the Weimar Republic, originally designed for German students, intersects differently with Czech historical memory—while subsequent events shape contemporary Czech memory of the interwar period, the scenario ~~centres~~ centers on Weimar-era deliberation (early 1930s), which predates the 1938 Munich Agreement and

cession of the Sudetenland by approximately ~~five~~ eight years. Nevertheless, the broader period connects directly to the Nazi occupation of 1939–1945 in Czech collective memory.

The Czech lower-secondary framework (Grades 6–9) includes the 1920s and 1930s, fascism, Nazism, totalitarianism, and work with historical sources, but does not define HPT as a separate competence (Ministerstvo školství, mládeže a tělovýchovy, 2023, pp. 54–58, 140, 143); curriculum documents describe intended rather than enacted provision (Kaleta, 2025). This documentary account covers only the lower-secondary subsample; no equivalent audit was conducted for the upper-secondary majority. At both levels, teachers confirmed that students had completed the interwar unit, which does not establish equivalent prior instruction across schools.

Cross-cultural validation studies should demonstrate that the adapted instrument preserves the factor structure, reliability, and validity relationships of the original (Hambleton et al., 2005). At minimum, this requires confirming the theorized factor structure through CFA, reporting reliability estimates appropriate for the item characteristics, and providing convergent validity evidence through expected correlations with related constructs. When the instrument will be used to compare groups or predict outcomes, measurement invariance testing becomes essential (American Educational Research Association et al., 2014).

2.3 Construct-Irrelevant Variance in Educational Assessment

The unified validity framework identifies construct-irrelevant variance as a principal threat to score interpretation (American Educational Research Association et al., 2014;

Messick, 1995). CIV occurs when systematic variance in test scores is attributable to factors extraneous to the target construct. When assessment content intersects with respondents' attitudes or social identities, CIV can arise through attitude-consistent responding: students whose beliefs align with test content may find certain response options more natural or appealing, inflating their scores without corresponding gains in the assessed competence~~—~~. This would be a form of what Messick (1995) terms construct-irrelevant easiness.

For the HPT instrument specifically, the concern is that the Weimar Republic scenario creates a *congruence pathway*—a mechanism whereby attitudinal similarity to item content lowers the cognitive effort required to endorse a response, inflating scores independently of competence. ~~Consider a contextualization item such as "His decision was understandable given the political and economic turmoil of the Weimar Republic." A student who endorses this statement because she has reconstructed the historical context produces a valid HPT response. But a student who endorses it because the sentiment resonates with her own political sympathies—not because she has engaged in historical reasoning—produces an inflated score. This would~~ In the Weimar scenario, every contextualization option describes Hannes as likely to vote for the NSDAP and every present-oriented option describes him as rejecting it, so the POP–CONT continuum coincides with the direction of the political choice (Wilschut & Schiphorst, 2019). A student can therefore reach a high score either by reconstructing the 1930 context or by finding an anti-democratic vote unobjectionable. Endorsement of the second kind—driven by the student's own political sympathies rather than by historical

reasoning—would represent construct contamination in Messick's (1995) terms—a systematic source of score variance unrelated to HPT competence. Evidence of internal structure, including measurement invariance across relevant subgroups, constitutes essential validity evidence when scores are used to compare groups or when the construct definition requires demonstrating that extraneous factors do not influence scores (American Educational Research Association et al., 2014).

An alternative theoretical prediction deserves mention. Research on authoritarian cognition suggests that high authoritarianism is associated with reduced integrative complexity—the cognitive capacity to hold and reconcile multiple conflicting perspectives simultaneously (Duckitt, 2001; Suedfeld & Tetlock, 1977). Because HPT requires precisely this kind of integrative capacity, authoritarian students might perform *worse*, not better. The direction of any bias, if present, was genuinely uncertain. Additionally, dual-process theories of cognition (Evans & Stanovich, 2013) suggest that structured assessment formats may channel deliberative processing, overriding the automatic attitude-retrieval processes that would produce attitude-consistent responding. If so, the assessment format itself may buffer against attitudinal interference.

The construct boundary is therefore consequential. Under broader accounts of historical empathy, affective engagement and morally responsive evaluation can be target-relevant aspects of understanding a past actor (Barton & Levstik, 2004; Endacott & Brooks, 2013). Under the narrower cognitive definition operationalized here, target variance consists of reconstructing context and integrating historically relevant considerations. Moral reaction or affect is not itself scored, and endorsement driven by option familiarity, task demands,

or attitude congruence is construct-irrelevant when it substitutes for that reconstruction. The rating data alone cannot determine which process produced an endorsement.

2.4 DIF and Measurement Invariance as Fairness Evidence

Differential item functioning and measurement invariance testing provide complementary approaches to evaluating measurement fairness (Chen, 2007; Cheung & Rensvold, 2002; Finch, 2005). DIF analysis examines whether individual items function differently across groups after controlling for the latent trait, identifying specific items that may be biased. Measurement invariance testing through multi-group CFA examines whether the overall measurement model holds across groups at three progressively restrictive levels: *configural invariance* (the same factors exist in both groups), *metric invariance* (items relate equally strongly to the factors in both groups), and *scalar invariance* (the scale origin is identical, so mean scores can be directly compared across groups).

For ordinal items, the weighted least squares mean and variance adjusted (WLSMV) estimator—a robust estimation method designed for categorical data—is recommended for CFA (Flora & Curran, 2004). Because ordinal items have discrete response categories rather than continuous scales, threshold-based invariance testing (which models the boundaries between response categories) replaces intercept-based approaches. The conventional criteria for evaluating invariance steps use changes in fit indices rather than chi-square difference tests, which are sensitive to sample size: ΔCFI $\leq$ .01 and ΔRMSEA $\leq$ .015 indicate that the more constrained model does not fit meaningfully worse (Chen, 2007; Cheung & Rensvold, 2002).

In the context of HPT measurement, establishing scalar invariance across ideology groups would mean that the factor structure, loadings, and item thresholds are equivalent for students with different political attitudes—a necessary condition for concluding that observed score differences (or the lack thereof) reflect true construct differences rather than measurement artifacts.

2.5 The Present Study

This study addresses two interrelated measurement questions:

1. ~~Does~~

RQ1. What psychometric evidence does the Czech adaptation of the Hartmann and Hasselhorn HPT instrument ~~demonstrate acceptable psychometric properties, including the theorized~~ provide, including evidence concerning a correlated three-factor ~~structure, adequate~~ representation, score reliability, and ~~convergent validity~~ convergence with historical knowledge?

2. ~~Does the instrument function fairly across students with different political attitudes, as evidenced by the absence of DIFand by scalar measurement invariance across ideology groups~~

RQ2. What evidence do DIF, measurement-invariance, and regression analyses provide about whether scores are affected by students' political attitudes?

~~We hypothesized that the three-factor structure would be confirmed and that the instrument would demonstrate measurement invariance across ideology groups.As~~

~~convergent validity evidence, we expected historical knowledge to correlate positively with HPT scores, consistent with the theoretical conceptualization of HPT as a knowledge-dependent competence~~The study and analysis plan were preregistered (https://osf.io/zsngy). The present measurement-focused organization, the six-item HPT composite as the primary outcome, and several analyses were adopted after registration, and not all registered analyses were implemented. Table S5 maps the registered hypotheses, omissions, and post-registration additions; findings from the latter are treated as exploratory or descriptive rather than as preregistered tests.

3. Method

3.1 Adaptation Process

The Czech HPT instrument was developed through a systematic translation and adaptation process following ITC guidelines (International Test Commission, 2017). The instrument was developed in Hartmann's (2008) dissertation and published by Hartmann and Hasselhorn (2008). Two bilingual Czech-English experts conducted independent forward translations from the published English version of the instrument (Hartmann & Hasselhorn, 2008). An independent backward translation was produced by a third bilingual expert unfamiliar with the original. Five Czech history educators at the secondary level reviewed the adapted items for conceptual equivalence, age-appropriateness, and curricular alignment. No items required substantive modification; minor wording adjustments were made to two items for naturalness in Czech. Reviewers ~~confirmed that the Weimar Republic scenario content was familiar~~ judged the scenario content accessible

to Czech secondary students ~~through the national history curriculum , given the direct connections between the interwar period and subsequent Czech historical experience (the Munich Agreement, the cession of the Sudetenland, and the Nazi occupation)~~given the curriculum coverage described in Section 2.2. This was expert-review evidence, not direct evidence from student interviews.

The adaptation preserved the ~~original instrument's structure: the~~ four-point fit-to-situation response format (1 = ~~*strongly disagree*~~*does not fit at all* to 4 = ~~*strongly agree*~~*fits very well*), the ~~three-factor item structure~~ three item categories (three items per ~~subscale~~category), and ~~the~~ reverse-scoring of POP items ~~were retained unchanged from the validated German version~~from the original instrument. All deviations from the original were documented transparently in the ~~OSF repository~~ public reproducibility package (https://doi.org/~~10.17605/OSF.IO/YNG37~~10.5281/zenodo.23494026). The ~~scenario narrative was~~ author separately cross-checked the scenario against the Czech history curriculum~~to confirm that all contextual references were accessible to the target population~~, but no direct student response-process study was conducted.

No cognitive pilot study (e.g., think-aloud interviews) was conducted prior to main data collection, which constitutes a limitation of the adaptation process (see Section 5.6).

3.2 Participants

The sample comprised 293 students from 20 classrooms across 10 schools in the Czech Republic, spanning lower-secondary (International Standard Classification of Education [ISCED] level 2, approximately ages 11–15; $n = 87$, 29.7%) and upper-secondary (ISCED 3,

approximately ages 15–19; $n = 206$, 70.3%) levels. The inclusion criterion was completion of the curricular unit on the interwar period. Schools were drawn from five Czech regions (Praha: 42.7%; Královéhradecký: 34.8%; Zlínský: 11.3%; Jihomoravský: 8.2%; Ústecký: 3.1%) and three funding categories (public: 90.8%; private: 6.5%; church-affiliated: 2.7%). Gender composition was 192 male (65.5%), 88 female (30.0%), and 13 identifying as another gender (4.4%). Students' most recent history grade averaged 1.71 ($SD = 0.92$; Czech scale: 1 = excellent, 5 = failing).

Schools were recruited through convenience sampling; the sample over-represents upper-secondary students relative to the national age cohort composition and should not be treated as a probability sample of Czech adolescents. Sample size was determined by an a priori power analysis specified in the preregistered protocol (~~OSF:~~ https://~~doi.org/10.17605/OSF.IO/YNG37~~osf.io/zsngy), targeting 80% power to detect standardized ideology effects of $\beta \geq .15$ in a two-level multilevel ~~model; the achieved~~ regression; the focal regression used N~~n~~ = ~~285–293 met this target~~282 students, above the registered minimum of 250. The calculation did not establish power for the DIF or MG-CFA analyses. Within each school, all participating students present on the day of administration completed the instrument battery during a regular class period (approximately 30–40 minutes). Teachers were present during administration but did not intervene in students' responses.

The sample's right-authoritarian attitude median was 2.33 on the five-point scale, and the historical-knowledge median was 3 of 6; fuller distributions appear in Section 4.4. No defensible student-, family-, or school-level socioeconomic indicator was collected.

Consequently, the sample's socioeconomic composition and any associated selection bias cannot be characterized.

3.3 Instruments

3.3.1 Historical Perspective Taking (HPT) Students completed the Czech adaptation of the ~~scenario-based HPT~~ Hartmann and Hasselhorn (2008) instrument. They read a narrative ~~about a young man in the Weimar Republic considering joining an extremist political movement, then responded to nine items on a 4-point Likert scale~~ in which Hannes discusses Germany's crisis and the 1930 election, then rated how well nine explanations fit his situation, including whether he could vote for an anti-democratic party such as the NSDAP, on a four-point fit-to-situation scale (1 = *does not fit at all* to 4 = *fits very well*). Three items each tapped ~~presentism~~ present-oriented perspective (POP1–POP3), ~~recognition of the agent's role~~ role of the historical agent (ROA1–ROA3), and historical contextualization (CONT1–CONT3). POP items capture present-centered ~~moral~~ judgments of the historical figure~~(e.g., evaluating his decision by contemporary standards)~~; these are reverse-scored (5 − POP, yielding a reversed range of 1–4) so that higher scores indicate ~~more contextualized~~ less present-oriented reasoning. ROA items ~~reflect awareness of the agent's social position and circumstances without full contextual integration~~explain action through familiar or stereotyped social roles. CONT items ~~represent the most sophisticated level, requiring~~ require students to situate the historical figure's deliberation within the specific political, economic, and social conditions of the Weimar Republic. The primary ~~composite was HPT_CTX6,~~ six-item HPT composite (hereafter, HPT composite) was the mean of reversed ~~POP and CONT items. HPT_TOT9~~

~~(adding ROA) served~~ present-oriented perspective and contextualization scores and therefore represents the continuum between these two response categories. The nine-item total score (adding the theoretically less certain role-of-the-agent category) served only as a secondary sensitivity outcome.

3.3.2 Right-Authoritarian Ideology (FR-LF mini) A six-item short form of the Fragebogen Rechtsextremer Einstellungen—Leipziger Form (Questionnaire on Right-Wing Extremist Attitudes—Leipzig Form; Decker et al., 2013), comprising acceptance of right-wing dictatorship (RD; 3 items) and National Socialist sympathy/relativization (NS; 3 items) facets, rated on a 5-point scale. The NS facet is theoretically the most direct operationalization of potential content congruence with the Weimar scenario.

3.3.3 Authoritarianism (KSA-3) The nine-item Kurzskala Autoritarismus (Short Scale of Authoritarianism; Beierlein et al., 2014), measuring authoritarian aggression, submission, and conventionalism on a 5-point scale. This instrument was used for a supplementary measurement invariance check using an alternative ideology operationalization.

3.3.4 Historical Knowledge (KN) Six multiple-choice items covering content relevant to the HPT scenario, scored dichotomously (sum score 0–6). This measure served as a convergent validity criterion, given the theoretical expectation that HPT is a knowledge-dependent competence.

3.3.5 Social Desirability (SDR-5) The five-item short form (Hays et al., 1989), rated on a 5-point scale with items SDR2–SDR4 reverse-coded. Included to evaluate whether HPT

scores reflect impression management rather than genuine reasoning. The source studies for the FR-LF included German respondents aged 14 years and older, whereas KSA-3 was developed for German-speaking adults aged 18 years and older and SDR-5 with adult medical outpatients and older adults. None therefore constitutes direct Czech adolescent validation; suitability rests on expert review and the sample-specific evidence reported here and in Table S4.

3.4 Analytic Approach

All analyses were conducted in R (version ~~4.4.2~~4.6.1) using lavaan (0.7.2) for CFA, mirt (1.47) for IRT-based DIF analysis, psych (2.6.5) for reliability estimation, and lme4 ~~/performance~~ (2.0.6) for intraclass correlations.

Factor structure. CFA compared one-factor (general HPT), two-factor (POP+CONT vs. ROA), and three-factor (POP, ROA, CONT) models using the WLSMV estimator, appropriate for ordinal item responses (Flora & Curran, 2004). CFA fit indices summarize how well a hypothesized factor structure reproduces the observed correlations among items; multiple indices are reported because each captures a different aspect of misfit. Model evaluation used CFI ($\geq$ .95 acceptable, $\geq$ .97 good), the Tucker–Lewis Index (TLI; $\geq$ .95), the Root Mean Square Error of Approximation (RMSEA; $\leq$ .08 acceptable, $\leq$ .05 good), and the Standardized Root Mean Square Residual (SRMR; $\leq$ .08).

Reliability. Internal consistency was assessed ~~via~~ using raw and polychoric Cronbach's α~~(raw and based on polychoric correlations) and~~ , McDonald's ω, ~~which does not assume tau-equivalence (the assumption that all itemsrelate equally strongly to the latent factor)~~

and is generally preferred for congeneric measures (measures whose items may differ in how strongly they relate to the factor;)and KR-20 for the dichotomous knowledge items. Reliability of the combined ideology score was estimated with the Mosier formula. Full methods and estimates are reported in Table S3.

Intraclass correlations. We I computed intraclass correlation coefficients (ICCs) at the school and classroom levels to characterise characterize the multilevel structure of the data and to evaluate whether clustering warranted multilevel approaches.

Clustered data handling. The DIF and substantive regressions used random intercepts for the nested data. The DIF, MG-CFAanalyses treat , and zero-order correlation analyses treated observations as independent, which is standard practice in applied DIF and measurement invariance research. To evaluate whether ignoring the nested structure introduces meaningful bias, design effects (DEFF—a multiplier indicating how much clustering inflates standard errors relative to a simple random sample) were computed post hoc. A design effect of 1.0 means clusteringhas no impact on precision; values approaching 2.0 indicate modest inflation of standard errors that can usually be tolerated . The primary composite (HPT_CTX6) had DEFF = 1.56, within the conventional ≤ 2.0 threshold. The secondary composite (HPT _TOT9) had DEFF = 2.16, marginally above this threshold; consequently, inferential claims are anchored primarily to HPT_CTX6, and HPT_TOT9 results should be interpreted with this caveat. [1] . Composite score ICCs do not establish that item thresholds, loadings, or their standard errors are unaffected by

[1] DEFF = $1 + (\bar{n}_c - 1) \times$ ICC, where $\bar{n}_c$ is the average cluster size (approximately 14.7 students per school). The TYPE=COMPLEX option in lavaan was not applied because the DIF analysis in mirt does not support clustered standard errors, and applying different corrections to DIF and MG-CFA would make the two sets of results less directly comparable.

clustering; therefore, uncertainty for these analyses may be understated. The zero-order correlation intervals are reported as descriptive, unadjusted intervals rather than cluster-robust inference.

Missing data and score construction. Composite scores required at least two answered items per three-item HPT subscale, four of six FR-LF items, seven of nine KSA-3 items, and four of five SDR-5 items; available responses were averaged. Missing knowledge responses were scored as incorrect, following the original analysis scripts. Reliability estimates used listwise-complete item sets, while correlations used pairwise-complete composite scores. These rules explain the analysis-specific sample sizes reported in the tables and supplement.

Differential item functioning. Low and High ideology groups were formed, as registered for the H4 sensitivity model, using tertile splits on a composite ideology score (mean of z-scored FR-LF and KSA-3), with the middle tertile excluded ~~to maximize contrast (~~(Low n ~~≈~~ = 96~~per group). This extreme-group design follows established practice in DIF research . A constrained~~ ; High n = 95). A constrained unidimensional multi-group graded response model (GRM item discrimination and ~~threshold~~ category-intercept parameters for each item by group are reported in Table S1 in the ~~OSF~~ supplementary materials) using a sequential item-release design tested each item for ~~uniform DIF (items are systematically easier or harder for one group at all ability levels) and non-uniform DIF (the group difference reverses depending on ability level) with Bonferroni correction (~~omnibus DIF by jointly freeing its discrimination and category intercepts, with Bonferroni-adjusted p-values (raw $p \times 9$) compared with a familywise α ~~= .01)~~of .05. The baseline model

constrains all nine items to equality across groups; each test then frees the discrimination and ~~threshold parameters~~ category intercepts for the focal item, yielding a likelihood-ratio comparison against the fully constrained baseline (an all-others-as-anchor strategy). This approach assumes that the remaining eight items are DIF-free when testing each focal item; iterative purification was not applied, which means that if multiple anchor items exhibited small DIF~~in the same direction, anchor contamination could mask detection .~~ , focal-item detection could be affected. Because the correlated three-factor model was retained for theory- and continuity-based subscale reporting, the unidimensional GRM is a pragmatic sensitivity model rather than a fully aligned measurement model; multidimensionality or local dependence may affect the item tests.

Sensitivity of DIF detection. With approximately 96 respondents per ideology group ~~, the likelihood-ratio DIF testsat Bonferroni-corrected $\alpha = .01$ (9 tests) are powered primarily to detect moderate-to-large parameter differences ($\Delta\beta \geq 0.5$ logits on discrimination or threshold parameters). Weak DIF effects ($\Delta\beta < 0.5$ logits) cannot be confidently excluded. This sensitivity threshold is consistent with the sample size requirements documented for IRT-based DIF methods~~ and nine Bonferroni-adjusted tests, statistical power was limited. No design-specific simulation was conducted, so the minimum detectable DIF magnitude is unknown. The extreme-group design ~~maximizes statistical contrast between ideology subgroups~~ increases ideological contrast at the cost of ~~reduced per-group sample size—a standard trade-off in DIF research when the grouping variable is continuous~~excluding the middle tertile and reducing group size.

Multi-group CFA. ~~Stepwise MG-CFA tested~~ The preregistration specified a multi-group

CFA with low and high ideology tertile groups as the sensitivity model for H4, testing configural, metric, and scalar invariance ~~across ideology groups using the three-factor model with WLSMV estimation. Invariance was evaluated using~~ of the contextualization items with ΔCFI $\leq .01$ and ΔRMSEA $\leq .015$ criteria. The reported analysis keeps the registered grouping, steps, WLSMV estimation, and criteria (Chen, 2007; Cheung & Rensvold, 2002), but extends the model from the contextualization factor to the full three-factor model.

Substantive models. Random-intercept linear models predicted each standardized HPT outcome from standardized FR-LF, KSA-3, historical-knowledge, and SDR-5 scores entered together, with intercepts for school and classroom. Thus, each reported ideology coefficient is mutually adjusted for the other ideology measure, knowledge, social desirability, and the nested grouping structure.

Convergent validity. Descriptive Pearson correlations between HPT composites and historical knowledge provided convergent validity evidence; Fisher-transformed intervals did not adjust for clustering.

Supplementary invariance check. To verify that invariance findings were not an artifact of the composite ideology definition, MG-CFA was also conducted using NS-only grouping (the facet most directly content-congruent with the Weimar scenario).

4. Results

The Results follow the two research questions. Sections 4.1–4.5 address RQ1 (factor structure, score precision, distributions, and clustering); Sections 4.6–4.8 address RQ2 at the item and model level; Section 4.9 reports zero-order correlations that bear on both

questions (convergence with knowledge for RQ1, ideology associations for RQ2); and Section 4.10 reports the adjusted ideology models for RQ2.

4.1 Factor Structure

CFA ~~supported the~~ showed good fit for the correlated three-factor model (POP, ROA, CONT~~) as best-fitting, outperforming the two-factor and one-factor alternatives (~~; Table 1). ~~The three-factor model showed excellent global fit:~~ Under the scaled WLSMV convention, this model had CFI = ~~.999~~.975, TLI = ~~.998~~.962, RMSEA = ~~.011~~ .039 (90% CI [.000, ~~.051~~.067]), and SRMR = .048. The two-factor model combining POP and CONT items on a single factor showed ~~acceptable but inferior~~ weaker fit (CFI = ~~.956~~.913, RMSEA = ~~.057~~.070), while the one-factor model fit poorly (CFI = ~~.926~~.866, RMSEA = ~~.073~~.086).

Table 1. *CFA Fit Indices for HPT Factor Models (WLSMV Estimator)*

Model	χ^2	*df*	CFI	TLI	RMSEA	90% CI
1-Factor	~~66.68~~ 81.54	27	~~.926~~ .866	~~.902~~ .821	~~.073~~ .086	[~~.051, .0~~
2-Factor (POP+CONT, ROA)	~~49.48~~ 61.30	26	~~.956~~ .913	~~.940~~ .880	~~.057~~ .070	[~~.032, .0~~
3-Factor (POP, ROA, CONT)	~~24.78~~ 34.26	24	~~.999~~ .975	~~.998~~ .962	~~.011~~ .039	[.000, ~~.0~~
Orthogonal bifactor (post-registration)	20.84	18	.993	.986	.024	[.000, .0

Note. WLSMV = weighted least squares mean and variance adjusted. All items were treated as ordered categorical. Reported chi-square, CFI, TLI, RMSEA, and RMSEA confidence-interval values use lavaan's scaled WLSMV convention; SRMR is the standard WLSMV value. The 2-factor model groups POP and CONT items on a single factor with

ROA on a separate factor. ~~Chi-square values are mean-and-variance adjusted (WLSMV).~~ Nested model comparisons require the DIFFTEST procedure rather than standard chi-square difference tests. The bifactor model has a general factor and orthogonal three-item specific factors. Its comparison with the correlated three-factor model is non-nested and parameterization-dependent. All $p < .001$ except the three-factor model ($p =$ ~~.418)~~ .080) and bifactor model ($p = .288$).

The ~~near-perfect global fit of the~~ three-factor ~~model reflects the~~ model's good global fit should be interpreted alongside the small item set ~~(nine items in three just-identified three-indicator factors—each subscale has exactly as many free parameters as observed statistics, leaving no room for misfitwithin subscales) and should be interpreted alongside local fit diagnostics: the largest modification index was 7.35 (POP1–ROA3 residual covariance; below the threshold of 10), and standardized residual correlations were small ($|r| \leq .13$). With only~~ and low-*df* specification: with three indicators per factor, there is limited opportunity to reveal within-factor misfit. The Czech data are compatible with the correlated three-factor specification, but this is not a test of cross-national equivalence.

As a post-registration sensitivity analysis, an orthogonal bifactor model had more favorable scaled fit indices (CFI = ~~24 for the~~ .993, RMSEA = .024, SRMR = .037; ΔCFI = +.018 relative to the correlated three-factor model~~(9 items, 3 factors, 24 free parameters against 45 observed statistics), there is minimal room for misfit; the near-perfect CFI is therefore a structural consequence of the low-*df* specification rather than evidence of an unusually well-fitting model. These results confirm that the Czech adaptation~~

~~preserves the theorized three-level structure of the original German instrument.~~). Thus, fit indices favor the more complex bifactor model, rather than unequivocally favoring the correlated three-factor model. That comparison is constrained by only three indicators per specific factor, the alternative parameterization, and its non-nested status. I therefore retain theory- and continuity-based subscale reporting as primary, while treating model uncertainty as a limit on strong structural claims.

Inter-factor correlations from the three-factor CFA were: POP–ROA Φ = .377, POP–CONT Φ = .509, ROA–CONT Φ = .631. These moderate-to-strong correlations ~~indicate meaningful associations among the HPT dimensions, with ROA and CONT showing the strongest link. Discriminant validityis supported because all inter-factor correlations are below .85, confirming that the three subscales capture related but distinct aspects of historical perspective taking.~~ are consistent with related but distinguishable item sets in this sample and provide bounded internal-structure evidence. They do not by themselves establish discriminant validity. Stronger evidence would require showing that the subscales relate differentially to external criteria in theoretically expected ways.

~~A supplementary bifactor model (one general factor plus three specific factors, in which each item loads on both the general factor and its subscale-specific factor) fit well (χ^2 = 14.70, df = 18, p = .682) but did not meaningfully improve over the correlated three-factor model (ΔCFI = .001). The low df (18) results from the additional cross-loadings consuming degrees of freedom, and the comparison with the correlated three-factor model (df = 24) should be treated cautiously given the different parameterisations. CONT items loaded primarily on the general factor (.47–.63), while POP and ROA retained~~

meaningful specific factor variance, supporting subscale-level interpretation.

4.2 Standardized Factor Loadings

Table 2 presents the standardized loadings from the In the three-factor CFA., CONT items loaded most strongly (.61–.72), followed by POP items (.30–.74; reverse-scored) and ROA items (.30–.67); all loadings were significant at $p < .001$. POP2 and ROA2 showed the weakest loadings(.30), at the conventional minimum threshold for item retention; it was they were retained to preserve fidelity to the original instrument structure. The range of loadings across subscales reflects the heterogeneity within each three-item set and is consistent with patterns reported in prior validations of short-form instrumentsFull item estimates, standard errors, and confidence intervals are reported in Table S2.

Table 2. *Standardized Factor Loadings for the Three-Factor HPT Model*

Item Subscale Loading *SE* 95% CI POP1 Presentism .74 .099 .54, .93POP2 Presentism .30 .076 .15, .44POP3 Presentism .50 .068 .37, .63ROA1 Recognition of Agent's Role .61 .071 .47, .75ROA2 Recognition of Agent's Role .30 .074 .15, .44ROA3 Recognition of Agent's Role .67 .074 .53, .82CONT1 Contextualization .72 .055 .61, .82CONT2 Contextualization .61 .059 .49, .72CONT3 Contextualization .64 .054 .53, .74

Note. POP items are reverse-scored (higher = more contextualized reasoning). All loadings significant at $p < .001$. WLSMV estimator with items treated as ordered categorical.

4.3 Reliability and Internal Consistency

Table 3 presents reliability coefficients for each HPT subscale. Raw Across HPT subscales, raw Cronbach's α values ranged from .47 (POP) ranged from .46 to .64 (CONT); polychoric α (appropriate for ordinal items) ranged from .53 to .69; and McDonald's ω ranged from .55 to .69. CONT demonstrated the strongest reliability, consistent with its highest average factor loadings.

Table 3. *Reliability Coefficients for HPT Subscales*

Subscale Items α (raw) α (polychoric) ω total Mean r_{ii} POP 3 .47 .53 .55 .226 ROA 3 .50 .53 .56 .249 CONT 3 .64 .69 .69 .372

Note. POP items are reverse-scored. α = Cronbach's alpha; from .54 to .70. The HPT composite and the nine-item total score reached ω total = McDonald's omega total . Mean r_{ii} .66 and .70. Reliability was modest and constrains individual interpretation. FR-LF had α = mean inter-item correlation.

These values are modest by conventional standards but structurally constrained by the three-item design: with k = 3, even moderate inter-item correlations (.20–.35) yield .67, KSA-3 had α in this range. The Spearman-Brown formula (which estimates how reliability would improve if subscale length were doubled) projects α = .64–.79 for six-item subscales, though this assumes tau-equivalence—an assumption violated when loadings range from .30 to .72, and the combined ideology score had Mosier reliability .80, 95% bootstrap CI [.74(Table 2)—so the projections should be treated as approximate upper bounds. McDonald's ω (, .84]. Knowledge had KR-20 = .55–.69) is more appropriate given unequal loadings (Table 2). The knowledge–HPT correlations reported below (r , and SDR-5 was weak (α = .22–.34)demonstrate that the instrument

~~carries genuine psychometric signal despite modest subscale reliability. Correcting the ideology–HPT correlation for measurement unreliability (disattenuation—an adjustment that estimates what the correlation would be if both measures had perfect reliability) yielded a disattenuated r = -.07, indicating that measurement error does not mask a meaningful ideology association. However, reliability for the composite ideology score (the mean of z-scored FR-LF and KSA-3) was not separately estimated, which limits the precision of this disattenuated estimate.~~30). Full subscale and predictor alpha, polychoric-alpha, omega, and interval estimates are reported in Table S3.

4.4 Descriptive Statistics

Table ~~4~~ 2 presents descriptive statistics. HPT scores followed the expected ~~developmental ordering (POP_rev > ROA > CONT), with contextualization producing~~ mean-score ordering: reversed present-oriented perspective scores were highest, followed by role-of-the-agent and contextualization scores. Contextualization produced the lowest scores (M = 2.71). ~~Ideology scores were below the scale midpoint (~~; this ordering may reflect item endorsement or difficulty and is not developmental evidence. Right-authoritarian attitude scores (FR-LF~~:~~) and authoritarianism scores (KSA-3) were below their scale midpoints (M = 2.48 ~~; KSA: M =~~ and 2.86~~), reflecting the rarity of strong~~ , respectively). The right-authoritarian ~~endorsement in mainstream adolescent samples.~~ attitude median was 2.33 (IQR [2.00, 3.00]) and 51 of 284 students (18.0%) scored above its midpoint. The authoritarianism median was 2.89 (IQR [2.53, 3.22]) and 106 of 283 students (37.5%) scored above its midpoint. On the mean of the two raw scales, 71 of 283 students (25.1%) scored above 3. Historical knowledge had a median of 3 (IQR [2,

4]), with 4.1% at the floor and 8.9% at the ceiling. No defensible student- or school-level socioeconomic measure was available.

Table 4.2. *Descriptive Statistics for Study Variables*

Variable	*n*	*M*	*SD*	Min	Max
HPT POP Present-oriented perspective (reversed)	287	2.97	0.64	1.33	4.00
HPT ROA Role of the historical agent	287	2.80	0.68	1.00	4.00
HPT CONT Historical contextualization	287	2.71	0.74	1.00	4.00
HPT CTX6 (primarycomposite (six items)	287	2.84	0.55	1.33	4.00
HPT TOT9 Nine-item HPT total score	287	2.83	0.49	1.67	3.89
KN Total Historical knowledge (0–6)	293	3.04	1.62	0.00	6.00
FR-LF RD Dictatorship acceptance	285	2.54	0.88	1.00	5.00
FR-LF NS Nazi-crime relativization	286	2.43	0.89	1.00	5.00
FR-LF Total Right-authoritarian attitudes	284	2.48	0.75	1.00	5.00
KSA-3 Total Authoritarianism	283	2.86	0.62	1.00	4.60 5.00
SDR-5 Total Social desirability	283	3.02	0.63	1.00	4.60

Note. HPT items scored on a 1–4 scale; POP items reverse-coded. FR-LF and KSA-3 scored on a 1–5 scale. KN scored as sum of correct responses (0–6).

4.5 Intraclass Correlations

Intraclass correlations indicated meaningful school-level clustering for most HPT outcomes (HPT_CTX6: ICC_school= Nested random-intercept models yielded

school/class-within-school/total-cluster ICCs of .041~~; HPT _TOT9: ICC_school = /.000/.041 for the HPT composite, .085; ROA: ICC_school = .102), consistent with between-school differences in instructional emphasis and student composition. Classroom-level variance was near zero for the primary composite but non-negligible for CONT (ICC_class = .033) and ROA (ICC_class = .104). These ICCs justify multilevel modelling for substantive analyses. The school-level variance /.000/.085 for the nine-item total score, .092/.011/.104 for role of the historical agent, and .026/.007/.033 for contextualization. The zero classroom component for the HPT composite~~ is consistent with ~~between-school differences in history instruction, curricular emphasis, and student composition. The corresponding design effects for the primary composite were modest (HPT_CTX6: DEFF = 1.56; HPT_TOT9: DEFF = 2.16; see Section 3.4 for computation and implications)~~the singularity warning in its focal model. These components describe score clustering but do not identify its source.

4.6 DIF Analysis

Table ~~5 presents~~ 3 presents omnibus DIF results for all nine HPT items. Using a constrained multi-group graded response model with likelihood-ratio tests~~and Bonferroni-adjusted significance ($\alpha = .01$)~~, no items were flagged~~for either uniform or non-uniform DIF. All adjusted~~ . Bonferroni-adjusted p-values ~~exceeded .01, indicating statistically equivalent item parameters across ideology groups. This means that at equal levels of underlying HPT competence, students with low and high ideological attitudes responded to each item in the same way—no individual item functioned differentially as a function of political attitudes~~were computed as raw $p \times 9$ and compared with a familywise α

of .05 (equivalently, per-test α = .0056). No DIF was detected between the low- and high-ideology groups with this sample and procedure; the magnitude that the design could reliably detect is unknown.

Table 5.3. *DIF Results per HPT Item (Likelihood-Ratio Tests from Multi-Group Graded Response Model)*

Item	χ^2	*df*	*p* (raw)	*p* (Bonferroni)	Flagged
POP1	11.18 10.46	4	.025 .033	.222 .300	No
POP2	9.42 9.01	4	.051 .061	.462 .547	No
POP3	9.50 9.72	4	.050 .045	.448 .408	No
ROA1	9.88 9.59	4	.043 .048	.383 .432	No
ROA2	2.90 3.13	4	.575 .536	1.000	No
ROA3	8.03 8.25	4	.091 .083	.815 .744	No
CONT1	1.65 1.51	4	.800 .825	1.000	No
CONT2	3.45 3.60	4	.486 .462	1.000	No
CONT3	9.43 9.63	4	.051 .047	.461 .424	No

Note. Likelihood-ratio chi-square statistics from constrained multi-group graded response models. Each test compares a fully constrained baseline (all items equal across groups) to a model freeing discrimination and threshold category-intercept parameters for the tested item. Low (n = 96) and High (n = 9695) ideology groups formed by tertile split on composite ideology score (middle tertile excluded). Bonferroni-adjusted *p*-values equal raw $p \times 9$ and were compared with familywise α = .01 (9 tests.05 (equivalently, per-test α =

.0056). 0 of 9 items were flagged. POP1 showed the largest DIF statistic (χ^2 = ~~11.18~~10.46, p_raw = ~~.025~~.033), well above the Bonferroni threshold after correction (p_adj = ~~.222~~.300). GRM item discrimination and ~~threshold~~ category-intercept parameters are reported in Table S1 ~~in the OSF supplementary materials~~ of the supplementary materials accompanying this manuscript.

~~Although no individual item reached significance after Bonferroni correction, five of nine items (POP1~~Because every other item served as an anchor, ~~POP3, ROA1, ROA3, CONT3) had raw p-values below .10. This clustering of near-significant results is consistent with a pattern in which multiple items share weak DIF in the same direction—precisely the scenario under which the all-others-as-anchor strategy without iterative purification is most vulnerable to anchorcontamination . Because the anchor set may itself be contaminated by small uniform DIF, the likelihood-ratio tests may underestimate the true magnitude of item-level differences. This pattern does not invalidate the overall null DIF finding, but it suggests that the absence of flagged items should~~ undetected DIF among those anchors could affect each test. The result should therefore be interpreted as "no ~~moderate-to-large DIF detected " rather than~~ DIF detected with this sample and procedure," not "no DIF present."

4.7 Measurement Invariance

Table ~~6~~ 4 presents the stepwise MG-CFA results. The configural model ~~demonstrated adequate fit (~~produced CFI = ~~.978~~.977, RMSEA = ~~.043,~~ .044, and SRMR = .074~~), confirming that the three-factor structure holds separately in both ideology groups. Constraining~~

factor loadings to equality across groups (metric invariance) produced no meaningful deterioration (. Adding equality constraints did not meaningfully worsen fit: metric ΔCFI $= .000, -.001$ and ΔRMSEA $= -.002$). Constraining both loadings and thresholds (scalar invariance) similarly maintained fit (.001; scalar ΔCFI $= +.002, .005$ and ΔRMSEA $= -.006$). Both transitions satisfy the established criteria of $|\Delta\text{CFI}| \leq .01$ and $|\Delta\text{RMSEA}| \leq .015$ .008. These changes fall within common fit-index criteria (Chen, 2007; Cheung & Rensvold, 2002), providing evidence for full scalar invariance. . All three solutions were admissible.

Table 6.4. *Multi-Group CFA Fit Indices Across Invariance Levels (WLSMV)*

Model	CFI	RMSEA	SRMR	ΔCFI	ΔRMSEA
Configural	.978 .977	.043 .044	.074	—	—
Metric	.978 .976	.041 .043	.081	.000 −.001	−.002 .001
Scalar	.980 .981	.035	.076	+.002 .005	−.006 .008

Note. ΔCFI and ΔRMSEA computed relative to the preceding model. Invariance criteria: $|\Delta\text{CFI}| \leq .01$, $|\Delta\text{RMSEA}| \leq .015$ (Chen, 2007). Low and High ideology groups formed by tertile a tertile-based split on composite ideology ($n \approx 96$ per group); complete item-response data were available for 92 Low and 90 High participants. Items treated as ordered categorical.

The SRMR increased slightly from configural (.074) to metric (.081), marginally exceeding the conventional $\leq .08$ threshold. This threshold was developed for maximum-likelihood estimation with continuous indicators and may not apply directly to WLSMV-estimated

models with polychoric residuals; the marginal exceedance should therefore be interpreted cautiously. The SRMR returned to .076 at the scalar step. ~~This pattern can signal partial loading non-invariance. The largest~~ The largest ordinary modification index at the metric step was ~~11.28 (a suggested cross-loading of~~ 11.22 and suggested a POP2 cross-loading on the ROA factor in the Low ~~ideology group), marginally above the conventional threshold of 10. This suggests a minor loading differencefor POP2 that is consistent with its weak loading (.30) in the overall CFA (Table 2) rather than evidence of systematic group-specific misspecification~~group. Because ordinary modification indices ignore equality constraints, this is a local cross-loading diagnostic, not evidence of a between-group loading difference.

~~Negative estimated residual variances (Heywood cases) occurred for ROA items in the Low ideology group in the configural and metric models. Such estimates indicate a non-positive-definite covariance matrix, which can invalidate fit statistics and render parameter estimates uninterpretable. While Heywood cases can arise with small per-group samples and WLSMV estimation of ordinal items—particularly with three-item factors—they signal potential modelinadmissibility~~ The admissible solutions and changes in CFI and RMSEA are compatible with scalar invariance under the fitted model. This remains qualified evidence rather than a ~~benign estimation artefact. The per-group sample sizes ($n \approx 82$–96) are at the lower boundary of what MG-CFA with WLSMV requires . The configural and metric invariance conclusions should therefore be qualified: they represent the best available evidence given sample size constraints, but the Heywood cases introduce uncertainty about the precision of the configural baseline. The~~

~~invariance results should be treated as convergent evidence alongside the DIF analysis rather than as definitive confirmation of scalar equivalence.~~ firm equivalence conclusion: the analysis extended the registered contextualization-only model to all nine items, used only 90–92 complete cases per extreme group, estimated three-indicator factors, and did not model school or classroom clustering.

4.8 Supplementary Invariance: NS-Only Grouping

~~To verify that invariance findings were not an artefact of the composite ideology grouping variable, we repeated the~~ Repeating the MG-CFA ~~using groups defined by~~ with groups formed by a tertile-based split on the NS facet alone (~~National Socialist sympathy/relativisation), which represents the most direct theoretical operationalisation of content congruence~~ unequal because of tied scores: $n = 126$ Low, 123 High), the facet most directly congruent with the Weimar scenario~~. With the NS tertile split, group sizes were $n = 126$ (Low) and $n = 125$ (High). The supplementary analysis largely supported scalar invariance (configural CFI = .960, RMSEA = .050, SRMR = .070;~~ , gave the same pattern: CFI did not decrease and RMSEA did not increase at either step (metric ΔCFI = +.002, Δ~~SRMR~~ RMSEA = ~~+.006~~ −.004; scalar ΔCFI = +~~.014~~.015, Δ~~SRMR~~ RMSEA = −~~.003~~). ~~The scalar ΔCFI of .014 marginally exceeds the conventional $\leq$ .01 threshold , indicating that full scalar invariance is not unambiguously confirmed for the NS-only grouping. The ΔRMSEA remained within acceptable bounds, and the direction of CFI change was positive (improved fit), which is atypical for genuine invariance violations. Nevertheless, given that the NS facet is the most theoretically proximal grouping variable and the larger per-group sample sizes ($n = 126/125$) make the criterion breach~~

~~more interpretable, partial scalar invariance—with possible threshold non-equivalence for individual items—cannot be ruled out. Full fit statistics for this supplementary analysis are available in the OSF repository.~~ .013; full fit statistics in Table S6). This post-registration analysis is descriptive robustness evidence, not a second confirmatory test.

4.9 Convergent Validity

Scenario-relevant historical knowledge correlated positively with all HPT outcomes: r = .34 ~~(HPT_CTX6)~~for the HPT composite, r = ~~.22 (CONT),~~ .23 for contextualization, and r = ~~.32 (POP_rev)~~.31 for reversed present-oriented perspective. These moderate correlations indicate that students with stronger knowledge of the relevant historical period scored higher on HPT~~, while also demonstrating that HPT is not reducible to knowledge alone—the shared variance (approximately 5–12%) leaves substantial HPT variance attributable to reasoning processes beyond factual recall~~. The scores were not empirically interchangeable, but their unshared variance cannot be attributed specifically to reasoning because it also includes measurement error and other unmeasured influences. A limitation of this evidence is that the KN items were written to cover content directly relevant to the HPT scenario, so the correlation may partly reflect shared specific-content activation rather than the broader "knowledge-dependent competence" relationship posited theoretically. A general historical knowledge measure would provide a stronger convergent validity test.

History grade also correlated with ~~HPT_CTX6~~ the HPT composite (r = −.153, p =

.010; negative sign reflects the Czech scale where 1 = excellent). This resembles the original German result rather than the Dutch applications, in which HPT scores were not significantly correlated with history grades (Huijgen et al., 2014, 2017). By contrast, ~~ideology measures showed negligible correlations with HPT (FR-LF–HPT_CTX6:~~ right-authoritarian attitudes showed a negligible correlation with the composite (r = −.05), and social desirability was unrelated to HPT outcomes (r = −~~.02~~ .05 to .01). ~~This pattern—significant knowledge correlations, null ideology and social desirability correlations—is consistent withan instrument that measures disciplinary reasoning rather than attitudes or impression management~~One exploratory exception was a negative association between authoritarianism and reversed present-oriented perspective (r = −.13, 95% CI [−.25, −.02]). The corresponding mutually adjusted standardized KSA-3 coefficient was β = −.166, SE = .066, unadjusted p = .013. This observed direction was not predicted: registered H2 predicted the opposite direction on raw POP. No reported test implemented the registered Benjamini–Hochberg correction, so this association should be treated as hypothesis-generating rather than confirmed. Overall, the positive knowledge associations and absence of detected associations for the primary ideology–HPT relationship are consistent with, but do not establish, the intended score interpretation.

Table ~~7.~~5. *Zero-Order Pearson Correlations Among Key Variables*

	HPT ~~CTX6~~ composite	~~CONT~~ Contextualization	Presentism ~~POP_rev~~ (reversed)	~~KN~~ Knowledge	Right-authoritarian ~~FR-LF~~ attitudes	~~KSA~~ A
HPT ~~CTX6~~ composite	—	[.78, .86]	[.71, .81]	[.23, .43]	[−.16, .07]	

	HPT CTX6 composite	CONT Contextualization	Presentism POP_rev (reversed)	KN Knowledge	Right-authoritarian FR-LF attitudes	KSA A
HPT CONT Contextualization	.82***	—	[.14, .36]	[.11, .33]	[−.10, .13]	
HPT POP_rev Present-oriented perspective (rev.)	.76***	.26***	—	[.20, .41]	[−.21, .02]	
KN Total Knowledge	.34***	.22 .23***	.32 .31***	—	[−.22, .01]	
FR-LF Total Right-authoritarian attitudes	−.05	.01 .02	−.09 .10	−.10	—	
KSA-3 Total Authoritarianism	−.03	.07	−.13*	.05	.52***	
SDR-5 Total Social desirability	−.02	.01	−.05	.03	−.19**	

Note. Correlations are below the diagonal and Fisher-transformed, unadjusted descriptive 95% confidence intervals are above it. Pairwise complete observations (n = 276–287). HPT POP 282–287; exact values in Table S3b). Present-oriented perspective is reverse-scored. KN = historical knowledge (Scale ranges: historical knowledge 0–6 (sum); FR-LF = right-authoritarian ideology (attitudes, authoritarianism, and social desirability 1–5); KSA-3 = authoritarianism (1–5); SDR-5 = social desirability (1–5). . Intervals and p-values do not adjust for school or classroom clustering. *** $p < .001$. ** $p < .01$. * $p < .05$.

Figure 1 visualizes the near-zero ideology association and positive knowledge association with the HPT composite. Mean HPT composite scores by composite-ideology tertile are reported in Table S7; the three confidence intervals overlap.

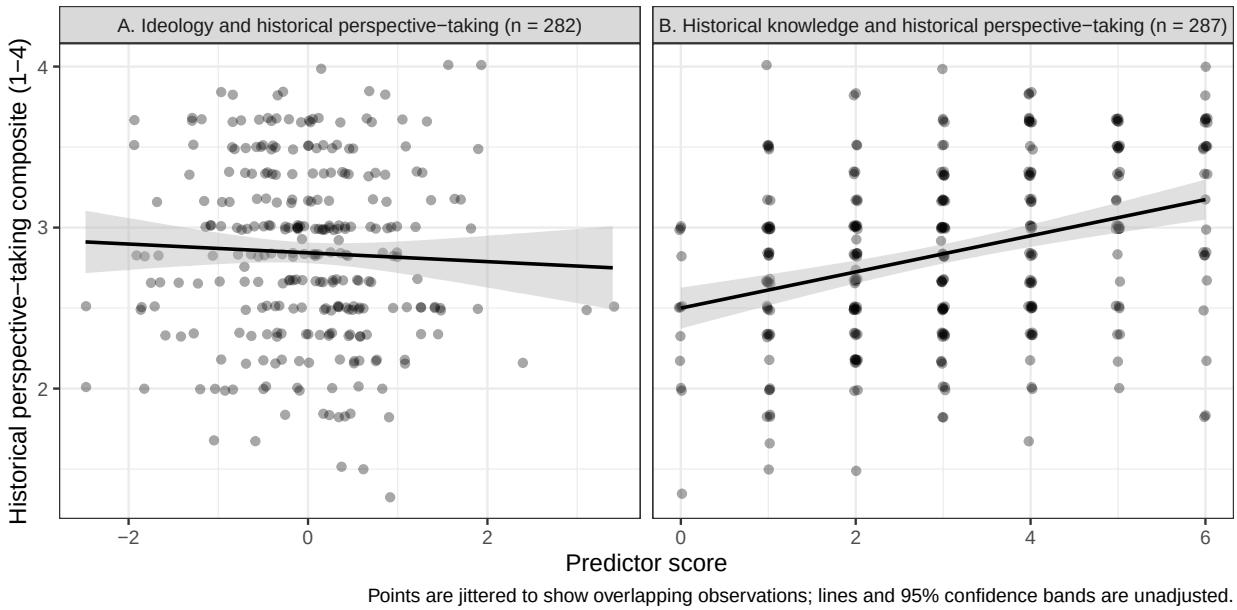


Figure 1: Observed relationships of the HPT composite with the combined ideology score—the mean of standardized right-authoritarian attitude and authoritarianism scores—(Panel A) and historical knowledge (Panel B). Points are jittered to display overlap; lines and shaded regions show unadjusted linear fits and 95% confidence intervals.

4.10 Substantive Context: Ideology-HPT Relationships

~~Ideology was unrelated to HPT scores across all model specifications: FR-LF~~ The mutually adjusted standardized right-authoritarian attitude coefficient was near zero for the HPT composite: β = ~~0.012~~.016, SE = ~~0.067~~.068, 95% CI [~~−0.120, 0.143~~.117, .149], p = ~~.863 for the primary outcome (HPT_CTX6). Historical~~ .817 (analysis n = 282). The fitted model issued a singularity warning because the classroom random-intercept variance was estimated as zero; the school intercept and fixed effects remained estimable, and

school fixed-effects sensitivity models gave the same substantive conclusion. Within the primary, preregistration-relevant model set, historical knowledge was the only consistent predictor (β = 0.21–0.34, $p < .001$). As an exploratory sensitivity analysis, equivalence tests used the Two One-Sided Tests (TOST) procedure, which reverses the logic of null-hypothesis testing by asking whether an effect is small enough to be declared practically negligible. The Smallest Effect Size Of Interest (SESOI) was set post hoc at $\pm$ 0.20 ~~standardised units, corresponding to 's () threshold for a "small"~~ standardized units, which I treated as the smallest practically relevant effect. This SESOI is wider than the preregistered power target of $\beta \geq .15$, meaning that effects between .15 and .20 cannot be confidently excluded; the TOST results should therefore be treated as exploratory rather than confirmatory. With the $\pm$ 0.20 boundary, the TOST results indicated that ~~ideology~~ right-authoritarian attitude effects at or above $\beta = .20$ are statistically ruled out ~~(all for~~ the primary relationship (TOST p ~~s < .003~~= .0034; 90% CI ~~for the primary outcome~~ [~~−0.10, 0.12~~.096, .127], entirely within the $\pm$ 0.20 SESOI). The ~~ideology coefficient~~ right-authoritarian attitude coefficient for the HPT composite remained non-significant across all sensitivity checks, including alternative HPT scoring composites, different ideology operationalizations, exclusion of high social desirability responders, random-slope models, and school fixed-effects specifications~~(all *ps* > .43)~~. These substantive findings complement the measurement evidence: ~~the instrument not only measures equivalently across ideology groups (DIF , invariance) but also yields scores that are uncontaminated by political attitudes at the composite level~~no DIF or composite-level ideology association was detected within the observed ideological range.

5. Discussion

5.1 Summary of Findings

~~The HPT instrument passed every fairness test applied. Factor structure replicated, DIF was absent, scalar invariance held, and ideology did not predict HPT scores. This is the first psychometric evaluation of a Czech adaptation of the Hartmann and Hasselhorn HPT instrument and the first investigation of ideological fairness for any HPT measure~~For RQ1, a correlated three-factor model showed good fit, although the post-registration bifactor model had higher fit indices and model uncertainty limits strong structural claims. The Czech adaptation ~~demonstrated the theorized three-factor structure, acceptable reliabilityfor three-item subscales, meaningful convergent validity with~~ showed modest subscale reliability, a positive relationship with scenario-relevant historical knowledge, and sensitivity to school-level variation. ~~Historical knowledge was the only construct that predicted HPT scores; political ideology , authoritarianism, and social desirability were all unrelated~~For RQ2, the results provide qualified fairness evidence: no DIF was detected with this procedure, fit-index changes were compatible with scalar invariance, and right-authoritarian attitudes did not predict the HPT composite. An unadjusted exploratory authoritarianism–reversed-presentism association was not subjected to the preregistered multiplicity procedure; other ideology and social-desirability associations were not detected, although weak reliability constrains the latter null associations.

5.2 Factor-Structure Evidence

The correlated three-factor model (POP, ROA, CONT) fit ~~substantially better than alternatives~~the Czech data better than the one- and two-factor alternatives. However, the post-registration bifactor fit indices were higher, and the non-nested, ~~confirming that the Czech adaptation preserves the dimensional structure of the original German instrument. This replication in a linguistically and educationally distinct context confirms that the item grouping holds in a Czech sample , though with a near-saturated model the structural confirmation is relatively undemanding (see Section 4.1)~~parameterization-dependent comparison means model uncertainty limits structural claims. This does not demonstrate cross-cultural equivalence, and the specification differs from the two-dimensional PCA pattern in the original German study. It shows only that the Czech data are compatible with separating the three item sets, with three indicators per factor and limited opportunity to reveal misfit. CONT items loaded most consistently (.61–.72), while POP2 and ROA2 showed weaker loadings (.30); these were retained for comparability but are candidates for revision in future adaptations.

5.3 Addressing Modest Reliability

Short scales trade breadth against precision. Under the attenuation paradox, raising reliability does not necessarily raise validity (see Loevinger, 1957, p. 678): three items that sample different considerations about one decision can serve the construct better than three near-duplicates with higher internal consistency. The subscale reliabilities (α = ~~.47~~.46–.64; ω = ~~.55~~.54–~~.69) fall below conventional benchmarks but are structurally~~

~~constrained by the three-item design—a feature of the original instrument, not a deficiency of the Czech adaptation. With k~~ .70) should be read against that trade-off, although the resulting precision is modest and limits individual-level interpretation. As in earlier applications, reliability remained a weakness, but the Czech composite estimates (ω = ~~3 and inter-item correlations of .22~~.66–~~.37, Spearman-Brown projections yield α = .64–.79 for six-item subscales. Despite modest reliability~~ , the instrument detected theoretically ~~expected knowledge–HPT relationships (r =~~ .70) were higher than the total-score alphas of .22–~~.34) and discriminated between HPT levels in the expected ordering. The disattenuated ideology–HPT correlation (r~~ .50 reported when the format was transferred to new content (Huijgen et al., 2014; Wilschut & Schiphorst, 2019), consistent with a structure that depends on the original scenario. The six- and nine-item HPT scores had higher descriptive one-factor estimates (ω = ~~-.065)confirms that even with perfect reliability, no meaningful ideology association would emerge. We recommend using composite scores (HPT_CTX6 or HPT_TOT9)~~ .66 and .70), so I recommend composite scores rather than individual subscales for ~~applied purposes.~~ group-level research. Modest reliability also attenuates validity coefficients: the knowledge correlation is a lower bound, and the ideology associations are attenuated in the same way, which limits the strength of the null fairness evidence. Associations involving the least reliable measures, especially SDR-5, call for particular caution.

5.4 Measurement Fairness Evidence

~~Scalar invariance was confirmed for the composite ideology grouping and largely supported for the NS-only analysis (with the caveat that the NS scalar ΔCFI marginally~~

exceeded the conventional threshold; see Section 4.8). These results indicate that the HPT instrument imposes largely equivalent measurement demands on students regardless of their political attitudes. Fit-index changes were compatible with scalar invariance for both ideology groupings, and the composite-group models were admissible. The limits listed in Section 4.7 nevertheless prevent a firm equivalence conclusion. The DIF analysis complements this at the item level: no item exhibited differential functioning after Bonferroni correction, which is particularly important for the CONT items most theoretically susceptible to ideological contamination, though the clustering of near-significant raw p-values warrants caution (see Section 4.6). adds item-level evidence, but no design-specific power analysis was conducted and the unidimensional GRM does not match the CFA structure. Together, these results provide qualified rather than definitive fairness evidence.

The correlation pattern—positive scenario-relevant knowledge–HPT associations, null ideology correlations, , as theoretically expected (van Boxtel & van Drie, 2018) and previously observed with prior knowledge (Huijgen et al., 2017), a near-zero primary ideology correlation, and null social desirability correlations—is consistent with the intended score interpretation (American Educational Research Association et al., 2014; Messick, 1995). However, the convergent evidence is bounded by the scenario-proximal nature of the knowledge measure (see Section 4.9), which limits the strength of the knowledge-dependent competence claim.

The near-zero ideology–HPT correlation ($r = -.05$) should not be interpreted as conclusive evidence that ideology plays no role in HPT performance. As discussed

~~in Section 2.3, two opposing pathways are theoretically plausible: a congruence pathway (whereby attitudinal alignment inflates scores) and a reduced integrative complexity pathway (whereby authoritarian cognition depresses contextualisation) . If both pathways operate simultaneously, their effects could cancel , producing a near-zero net correlation that masks two moderate-sized opposing effects. The present data cannot distinguish a genuine null from cancelling pathways.~~ admits several explanations that the present data cannot distinguish: a genuine null; congruence and reduced-integrative-complexity pathways (Section 2.3) that cancel each other; a format effect, if structured fit-to-situation ratings channel deliberative processing and suppress attitude-consistent responding (Evans & Stanovich, 2013); or task-demand compliance, if students in a school assessment avoid presentist endorsements about a Nazi-era decision regardless of their own attitudes. The null SDR-5 correlations argue only weakly against the last explanation, because a brief self-report scale may not capture classroom task demands. If the format explanation holds, the fairness conclusion is conditional on the closed-ended rating format and does not extend to open-ended HPT assessments. Limitation 8 in Section 5.6 describes response-process evidence that could separate these explanations.

The present fairness evidence applies to mainstream Czech adolescent samples with restricted ideological range. Users in contexts with greater political ~~polarisation~~ polarization should conduct their own DIF and invariance analyses before assuming equivalent measurement.

5.5 Implications for Assessment Practice

The core practical message is that politically charged assessment content ~~does not automatically introduce~~ need not produce detectable construct-irrelevant ~~variance—but this conclusion~~ variance in every application. In this study, no HPT composite association or DIF flag was detected at the available sensitivity. This pattern is bounded by the ~~present sample's~~ restricted ideological range and should not be generalized beyond the single structured, closed-ended ~~formats~~ scenario without further evidence.

The evaluation protocol used here ~~provides an evidence-based model~~ illustrates a possible workflow for evaluating fairness when assessment content intersects with respondents' attitudes. ~~This protocol is not specific to HPTor history education; it applies to any~~ Although developed for HPT, the workflow may inform studies of other scenario-based assessments~~where content carries attitudinal valence—moral reasoning instruments using politically divisive dilemmas, science literacy assessments touching evolution or climate change, and civic education assessments involving controversial policies~~valence.

The general approach involves five steps:

1. Identify the attitudinal dimension theoretically most likely to produce CIV.
2. ~~Form~~ Model the attitude continuously (for example, in a MIMIC model) or, where necessary, form extreme groups on that dimension.
3. Test DIF at the item level.
4. Test measurement invariance at the model level.
5. Examine ~~convergent and discriminant correlations to verify that construct scores relate to theoretically expected variables and not to the attitudinal dimension~~a

prespecified set of expected relationships, including whether HPT dimensions relate differentially to external outcomes as theory predicts.

~~The format itself may be a fairness mechanism. If scenario-based formats channel deliberative processing and override automatic attitude-retrieval , then the instrument format—not just the construct—buffers against motivated reasoning. However, this hypothesis has an important implication: if the format itself suppresses attitudinal responding, then the present fairness conclusion is conditional on the closed-ended Likert format and cannot be extended to open-ended HPT assessments where ideology could operate through different cognitive pathways.~~

~~Several design features may explain the instrument's resistance to attitudinal contamination: the scenarioprovides contextual information that channels deliberative processing, the Likert items require evaluating propositions about a historical figure rather than expressing personal attitudes, and the school assessment context may activate an academic frame. These are hypotheses, not conclusions—the present study was not designed to test them experimentally, and doing so would require comparing structured and open-ended formats using the same content.~~

~~An alternative explanation for the observed measurement equivalence deserves consideration. In a school context where the scenario involves a Nazi-adjacent historical figure, students may uniformly avoid endorsing presentist responses—not because they are engaging in genuine historical reasoning, but because contextualisation is the socially safe response regardless of one's actual political attitudes. If task-demand compliance produces equivalent response patterns across ideology groups, the resulting~~

~~measurement invariance would reflect shared social desirability pressure rather than genuine absence of ideological influence on reasoning. The null SDR-5 correlations provide partial evidence against this interpretation, but a brief self-report measure of social desirability may not capture the specific task demands operating in a classroom assessment of politically sensitive historical content.~~

5.6 Limitations

Several limitations qualify these findings.

1. ~~*Single country and scenario.* The study uses one national context and one historical scenario; whether~~ *Content validity.* The instrument samples the HPT domain through a single scenario. Nine ratings of one Weimar voting dilemma provide repeated judgments about the same content, not nine independent samples of the domain, so the scores risk construct underrepresentation (Messick, 1995). Scenario-specific wording, knowledge, familiarity, and moral salience therefore cannot be separated from perspective taking itself. The present evidence supports interpretations of performance on this task, not of HPT as a general competence, and the fairness findings ~~generalise to other contexts remains to be established~~are bounded in the same way. Stronger content evidence would require parallel item sets applied to several scenarios that vary in period, place, political valence, and familiarity.

2. *Restricted ideological range.* ~~Only 17.7%~~ Depending on the measure, 18.0% (FR-LF), 37.5% (KSA-3), or 25.1% (their raw-score mean) of respondents scored above the scale midpoint~~on ideology measures~~, so the DIF and invariance analyses compare

moderately elevated to low ideology, not genuine political extremism. The null ideology finding should be interpreted as "no evidence of CIV in this range-restricted sample" rather than as a general demonstration that politically charged content is fair.

3. *Limited DIF power.* With $n \approx 96$ per group, ~~the analysis was powered primarily to detect moderate-to-large effects ($\Delta\beta \geq 0.5$ logits); weak DIF effects cannot be confidently excluded~~DIF power was limited. A formal power simulation for the GRM likelihood-ratio test at Bonferroni-corrected α was not conducted~~; future work should quantify~~ , so the minimum detectable DIF magnitude ~~for this design~~is unknown.

4. *Gender imbalance.* The sample was 65.5% male~~. Gender is a documented moderator of authoritarian attitude endorsement in adolescent samples~~, and no DIF or sensitivity analysis by gender was conducted. ~~If male students drive both ideology variance and the null finding, the fairness conclusion may not hold for~~ The fairness conclusion should therefore be replicated in a more gender-balanced sample~~s~~.

5. *Single-country convenience sampling and unavailable socioeconomic data.* The sample came from one country, over-represented upper-secondary students, and was not probabilistic. Because no defensible socioeconomic indicator was collected, neither socioeconomic coverage nor selection along that dimension can be assessed.

6. *Modest reliability.* Subscale reliabilities (α = ~~.47~~.46–.64; ω = .54–.70) constrain individual-level score interpretations; future adaptations should consider expanding subscale length. ~~Omega hierarchical (ω_h) from the bifactor model was~~

not computed; this index would clarify what proportion of subscale variance is attributable to the general HPT factor versus specific subscale factors.

7. *Method and format constraints.* All measures were self-report instruments administered in a single session. The closed-ended Likert fit-to-situation rating format may not generalise generalize to open-ended HPT assessmentswhere ideology could operate through different cognitive mechanisms , where responding may rely on different cognitive processes (Smith, 2017; Smith et al., 2018).

8. *No response process evidence.* The critical unanswered question is whether Czech students actually invoke historical reasoning when responding—or whether the structured format produces contextualising responses through a different cognitive pathway. Cognitive interview studies could resolve thisThink-aloud or cognitive-interview studies, extending Huijgen et al. (2017), could compare the same content in rating and open-response formats; written explanations have detected change that closed ratings in this format missed (Wilschut & Schiphorst, 2019). Evidence use and integration of conflicting historical considerations would support contextual reconstruction; explicit moral evaluation or affective engagement would identify processes outside this instrument's narrow cognitive scoring target; paraphrase and option- matching comments would indicate format-driven responding; and endorsement tied to one's present political position would indicate attitude congruence. These observable indicators could distinguish pathways that the present ratings cannot separate.

5.7 Recommendations

For researchers developing or adapting HPT instruments: (a) report ω alongside α for short subscales, with Spearman-Brown projections for context; (b) evaluate fairness through DIF and measurement invariance for theoretically relevant grouping variables; (c) consider revising weak-loading items (POP2, ROA2) while preserving the theoretical structure; (d) expand subscale length to improve reliability; ~~and~~ (e) replicate fairness evaluations across diverse samples, scenarios, and cultural contexts; and (f) test whether the POP, ROA, and CONT subscales differentially predict external criteria, which would provide stronger discriminant evidence than factor correlations alone.

5.8 Conclusion

~~The Czech adaptation~~ For this single Weimar scenario, the Czech data were compatible with a correlated three-factor representation of the Hartmann and Hasselhorn HPT ~~instrument preserves the three-factor structure of the original, produces~~ item sets and produced scores that relate to scenario-relevant historical knowledge in theoretically expected ways~~, and functions with largely equivalent measurement properties across students with different political attitudes~~. Fit-index patterns were compatible with measurement invariance across ideology groups, but small extreme groups and unmodeled clustering prevent a firm equivalence conclusion. At the sensitivity levels afforded by the present sample and in the observed ideological range, ~~political ideology was unrelated to HPT scores across all model specifications.~~ right-authoritarian attitudes were unrelated to the HPT composite. An unadjusted exploratory authoritarianism association

with one subscale was not subjected to the preregistered multiplicity procedure.

For researchers and assessment developers, the practical implication is that structured scenario-based assessments can ~~employ politically sensitive historical content without detectable measurement bias—at least in mainstream classroom settings with restricted ideological range~~be evaluated for attitude-related measurement differences using complementary item-, model-, and relationship-level checks. In this sample, those checks detected no bias in the HPT composite at the available sensitivity. Whether this ~~conclusion~~ pattern extends to more ~~polarised~~ polarized populations, open-ended assessment formats, or different historical scenarios remains an open empirical question. The evaluation protocol ~~demonstrated~~ illustrated here—CFA, DIF, MG-CFA, and ~~convergent/discriminant correlations—provides a replicable~~ a prespecified network of external relationships—provides a possible template for answering that question wherever attitudinally charged content meets competence assessment.

Data Availability Statement

De-identified data, annotated analysis scripts, ~~the complete instrument battery (in Czech), supplementary materials, and all deviations from the original instrument are available on the Open Science Framework~~ rendered outputs, and documentation of the instrument adaptation and deviations are available in the Zenodo reproducibility package (https://doi.org/~~10.17605/OSF.IO/YNG37~~10.5281/zenodo.23494026). Data are provided in machine-readable formats (RDS and xlsx) accompanied by a full variable codebook (PDF). The ~~analysis pipeline consists of seven numbered R Markdown scripts~~

that reproduce all reported resultspipeline contains five numbered analytic R Markdown reports, two documentation reports, shared scoring helpers, and a revision-reporting script; a README file documents the directory structure, execution order, software requirements, and mapping of scripts to manuscript tables and figures. Supplementary materials (Table S1: GRM item parameters) Tables S1–S5) accompany this manuscript and are included in the OSF repository. package. Third-party instrument files and item text are excluded pending documented redistribution permission; the manuscript and package documentation identify and cite the measures used. Zenodo hosts the public reproducibility package. The study design, hypotheses, and analysis plan were preregistered on OSF (https://osf.io/zsngy) prior to data collection; deviations and omissions are disclosed in Table S5.

Conflict of Interest Disclosure

The author declares that he complies with the PCI rule of having no financial conflicts of interest in relation to the content of the article, and has no non-financial conflicts of interest.

Ethics Statement

This study involved secondary school students completing questionnaires during regular class periods. Under Czech law (Act No. 110/2019 Sb., on the processing of personal data), ethics committee approval is not required for non-interventional educational research involving anonymous questionnaires where no personal data are collected. The principal of

each participating school gave permission for data collection; parents were not separately informed or asked for consent. Participation was voluntary; students were informed about the study's purpose and their right to decline participation without consequences. All responses were de-identified at the point of data entry. No personally identifiable information was collected or stored. The study followed the principles of the Declaration of Helsinki for research involving human participants.

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Author Contributions (CRediT)

Juda Kaleta: Conceptualization, Methodology, Software, Formal analysis, Investigation, Data curation, Writing — original draft, Writing — review & editing, Visualization, Project administration.

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- *Brainstorming and scripting assistance:* Claude (Anthropic) — used for exploring conceptual framing, structural alternatives, and scripting support for data processing and analysis workflows.
- *Language editing:* Grammarly — used for grammar and style checking.

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This checklist must be completed and included as an appendix at the end of your preprint prior to submission to PCI Psychology. Manuscripts without this document included as an appendix will be returned to authors without review.

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Section 1: Data

Does your manuscript contain reports of any data?

[X] Yes (continue with next question)

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Are appropriately ~~anonymised~~ anonymized raw data available within a trusted digital repository?

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Do you indicate in the manuscript how the sample size was determined?

[X] Yes. (Section ~~3.4~~3.2: a priori power analysis targeting 80% power to detect $\beta \geq .15$)

☐ No, justification:

Do you report all data exclusions (e.g., outliers, careless responders)?

[X] Yes. (Section 3.4 and ~~4.6: Table S5: the~~ middle ideology tertile ~~excluded for DIF extreme-group design; all exclusions reported~~was excluded for the DIF and MG-CFA analyses, as registered for the MG-CFA sensitivity model; this analysis-specific exclusion is reported.)

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Do you report all inclusion/exclusion criteria and when they were established?

[X] Yes. (~~Inclusion/exclusion criteria~~ Participant eligibility is described in Section 3.2 and was preregistered; analysis-specific exclusions are described in Section~~s~~3.4 ~~–3.5 and were preregistered prior to data collection~~and Table S5.)

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Are all measures, questions, and/or conditions used in the study described in the manuscript or available in the supplemental material?

~~**XYes.** (All instruments described in Sections 3.1–3.3; full Czech-language instrument battery available on OSF:)~~

☐ ~~No, justification:~~ Yes.

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Are third-party analysis scripts/code (e.g., R, Stata), codebooks, or other relevant documentation available within a trusted digital repository?

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Does your manuscript contain any research materials (e.g., stimuli, programming code, questionnaires, interview protocols)?

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~~**XYes, available at this link:** (Czech-language versions of all questionnaires: HPT, FR-LF, KSA-3, SDR-5, and historical knowledge test)~~

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Do you clearly indicate in the manuscript which parts were preregistered and which parts were not?

[X] **Yes.** (~~Preregistered components include hypotheses H1–H2, primary multilevel models, DIF/MG-CFA analyses, and sample size determination; the TOST equivalence analysis is explicitly labelled "exploratory" in Section 4.10 as it used a post-hoc SESOI wider than the preregistered power target~~Section 2.5 gives a concise disclosure of post-registration changes and omitted registered analyses. Table S5 distinguishes registered tests, omissions, implemented modifications, and post-registration analyses.)

☐ No, justification:

Are all preregistered analyses reported in the text or linked in the supplemental material?

☐ Yes.

[X] ~~**Yes.**~~**No, justification:** ~~(All preregistered hypotheses and analyses are reported in Sections 4.1–4.10 and the supplementary materials)~~ The registered continuous-ideology

MIMIC model, both FR-LF-by-knowledge and KSA-by-knowledge moderation analyses and their simple slopes, clustered correlation comparison, complete covariate set, one-tailed tests, Benjamini–Hochberg correction, and registered missing-data rule were not all implemented. Table S5 reports these omissions and the analyses used instead.

~~☐ No, justification:~~

Are all deviations from the preregistration plan clearly disclosed in the manuscript (either in text or in a table)?

[X] Yes. (~~One deviation: TOST SESOI set post hoc at~~ Section 2.5 and Table S5 disclose the changed inferential hierarchy, omitted registered procedures, instrument discrepancies, and post-registration additions. TOST and its ± 0.20 ~~instead of the preregistered power target of $\beta \geq .15$; disclosed in Section 4.10 and the analysis is labelled exploratory~~SESOI are explicitly labelled exploratory.)